‘timidity, deceit, and falsehood have been mixed up with a little honesty, simplicity and humility and made into a paste to which the name of Gujarati has been given’. This time it was Ibrahim Sultan, a Timurid mirza and descendant of Timur, who was railing against the control of the Padshah at Sarnal. Akbar left his two young sons and harem in Cambay and galloped in the night against the insurgents with a small force of only 200 men that included his Kachhwaha noblemen.

When they arrived at the Mahi, Akbar and his men plunged into the river and scrambled up the steep banks on the other side and were told that Ibrahim Sultan Mirza had run away from Sarnal. His men had remained to fight, however, and now Akbar’s small band of warriors found their horses stumbling on the broken ground bristling with thorny bushes and trees. Seeing his men falter, Akbar spun his horse around to face them and ‘roared loudly like a lion and called his men…and their courage returned’. For Akbar there could be no countenancing of defeat or fear and he found in his Rajput officers an equal and clear gallantry. Man Singh, now twenty-two years old, begged to be allowed ahead in the coveted vanguard while Bhagwant Das rode bridle to bridle with the Padshah as they charged and sliced at the enemy in the narrow ravines and passes. The two men fought with lance and scimitar as time seemed to stand still amid the panting horses and the slashing blades and the curving of the sun through the sky, but finally the enemy was defeated on 23 December 1572. Bhagwant Das was awarded a banner and kettledrums, the first Hindu officer to obtain these significant honours. There was a sad loss for the Kachhwahas, however, in the death of Bhupat, one of Raja Bharmal’s sons, who was killed in the fierce fighting. Bhupat’s sister, Harkha Bai, waiting with the harem in Cambay would have been devastated. When the imperial retinue returned to Agra after the Gujarat campaigns, Akbar would send Harkha Bai to her natal home in Amer, a consolation for her bereaved parents.

While Akbar was occupied in Gujarat, he was also closely involved in supervising operations in the eastern reaches of his kingdom. A letter to Munim Khan written at this time shows the Padshah’s meticulous attention to detail. In the letter Akbar lists to Munim Khan the artillery and munitions he is having sent to him from the capital. ‘We have ordered that Rumi Khan should make ready 500 pieces of Daudi cannons and fifty pieces of Islam Shahi cannons, with fuses and carriages and send them…’ wrote Akbar. ‘5000 chandra bans and kahak-bans Mazamdarani (a type of rocket made of